

The Impact of Generative AI on the CSCW Landscape: Insights from HCI Education, Industry Dynamics, and Funding Perspectives

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Abstract

Recently, we have witnessed emerging research agendas on explicating new opportunities, risks, and harm of generative AI from a CSCW perspective. Built upon these ongoing conversations and dialog, we believe that beyond merely discussing generative AI's impacts on specific CSCW research directions, it is equally critical to promote in-depth discussions across academia and industry to reflect upon generative AI's multidimensional impacts on the overall CSCW landscape, including: how we train and educate our next generation of CSCW and HCI researchers in the age of generative AI, how generative AI is affecting the tech industry trajectories and our students' future job prospects in the tech industry, how we can better approach academia-industry collaboration to deal with such impacts, and how the growing focus on generative AI may (re)shape funding opportunities for future CSCW research topics. Featuring a group of panelists who are academic leaders in HCI/CSCW education and industry experts, the goal for this panel is to promote community-wide discussions and collective reflections on these key questions that are crucial for sustaining the future of CSCW.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Collaborative and social computing**; **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

generative AI, CSCW research, online communities, HCI, funding, industry perspectives

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1 Introduction

Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) systems (e.g., ChatGPT and Midjourney) are trained using large datasets and can generate music, texts, videos, arts, and designs that are similar to what humans could create based on learned and reproduced patterns from the training datasets [14, 26]. Recently, there is a growing trend to use these systems in various aspects of our daily lives, ranging from medicine and health care [17], learning and education [3], creative writing [9], and software/game development [18, 28, 29] to even online emotional support [6, 20], among others. These powerful technological advances have highlighted the promising new approaches of using AI to shape how people work, live, and interact in various forms of collective lives such as groups, organizations, and communities [1], which is a core research question in CSCW.

Indeed, we have witnessed emerging research agendas on explicating new opportunities, risks, and harm of generative AI from a CSCW perspective. Examples include generative AI's new role in supporting or harming online communities, such as: AI for moderating online harassment and cyberbullying [8, 24], AI for detecting and mitigating sexual risks [7, 30], and AI for youth online safety [2, 22]. Others have focused on how to leverage generative AI systems to facilitate various creative practices and workflows. Such conversations have revealed both the potential of using generative AI to promote social interactions and collaborative creation [11, 21, 26] and concerns about how generative AI may replace the human creative workforce and redefine the concept of creativity [4, 19, 27, 28], as highlighted in a panel discussion at CSCW 2024 [5]. Furthermore, researchers have reflected upon how generative AI may even expand the scope of CSCW research, asking such questions as "Is Human-AI Interaction CSCW?" [16].

Built upon these ongoing conversations, we believe that beyond merely discussing generative AI's impacts on specific CSCW **research directions**, it is equally critical to promote in-depth discussions across academia, industry, and funding agencies to reflect upon generative AI's multidimensional impacts on the overall

CSCW landscape, including: how we **train and educate** our next generation of CSCW and HCI researchers in the age of generative AI, how generative AI is affecting the **tech industry trajectories** and our students' future job prospects in the tech industry, how we can better approach **academia-industry collaboration** to deal with such impacts, and how the growing focus on generative AI may (re)shape **funding opportunities** for future CSCW research topics.

In summary, CSCW as a community must ask: *What is next? How can we better prepare our community members, including students and early career researchers, for the AI era and the potential post-AI era?* Featuring a group of panelists who are academic leaders in HCI/CSCW education and industry experts from tech giants, the goal for this panel is to promote community-wide discussions and collective reflections on these key questions that are crucial for sustaining the future of CSCW.

2 Panel Themes and Goals

In this panel, we aim to discuss important questions and considerations about generative AI's multidimensional impacts on the overall CSCW landscape that go beyond specific research agendas or directions, ranging from HCI education and industry trajectories to funding perspectives. Specifically, we will focus on the following topics and example questions in this panel.

How should we train and educate our next generation of CSCW and HCI researchers in the age of generative AI? There have been growing discussions surrounding generative AI's impacts on both computer science education (e.g., teaching coding and programming [13]) and HCI education, such as using generative AI tools to generate synthetic HCI research Data [10], help students understand HCI theories and principles [12], and facilitate the ideation and rapid prototyping phase of interactive device design [23], among others. Still, what is lacking is a comprehensive image of how we should train and educate our next generation of CSCW and HCI researchers in the age of generative AI, which include but is not limited to: curriculum development, methodology training, research skills and ethics, and career trajectories. Some example questions we will discuss in this panel are: *What are some potential new skillsets our next generation of CSCW and HCI researchers would need in the age of generative AI? What should HCI/CSCW academic programs in higher education institutions do to help our students gain such new skills and knowledge? What should HCI/CSCW academic programs in higher education institutions do to also help faculty and early career researchers to build their research agenda, seek funding, and train students in the age of generative AI?*

How is generative AI affecting tech industry trajectories and academia-industry collaboration in HCI/CSCW? Since OpenAI's release of ChatGPT in November 2022, Generative AI continues to transform the tech industry all over the world. Almost all tech giants, including Microsoft, Google, Apple, and Meta, are competing to develop their own generative AI systems and implement them in their own products (e.g., Microsoft's Copilot¹, Google Gemini², Apple Intelligence³, and Meta AI⁴). Along with

the current boom of generative AI in the tech industry, the requirements for more powerful hardware, more abundant processing resources, access to even larger training datasets and data centers, and new infrastructures supporting these advanced systems are also accelerating, as warned in a 2024 Forbes report [15]. With the rapidly growing cost to implement generative AI and keep in pace with the heated AI competition in the tech industry, how this shift of priority and focus may affect HCI/CSCW graduates' job prospects in industry and future academia-industry collaboration in HCI/CSCW becomes a key concern. As such, some example questions we will discuss in this panel are: *How would the recent AI boom affect HCI/CSCW students' job prospects in the tech industry? How would the recent AI boom affect future academia-industry collaboration in HCI/CSCW? How can we better understand and approach generative AI's unique opportunities and challenges for the CSCW community across academic and industry contexts? What would be the best methods and approaches to facilitate academia-industry collaboration within the CSCW community in the age of generative AI?*

How might the growing focus on generative AI (re)shape funding opportunities for CSCW researchers? The recent AI boom is also reflected upon the changing landscape of funding opportunities for HCI and CSCW researchers, as various countries have highlighted AI design, development, and policy-making as one of their national priorities. For example, the European Union has developed the AI Act. It is the world's first comprehensive AI law, which directly regulate how AI would be used in Europe and funding decisions regarding AI research⁵. The National Science and Technology Council in the USA considers AI "one of the most powerful technologies of our time" [25]. The National Science Foundation in the USA has invested in foundational artificial intelligence research since the early 1960s, which has also emphasized the need for advancing responsible AI systems as a national priority to serve the public good, such as leveraging AI to address societal challenges rather than introducing new ethical, legal, and social risks⁶. Some example questions we will discuss in this panel are: *What would be some new expectations for CSCW researchers who plan to seek government funding to support their research on generative AI? What would be some new expectations for CSCW researchers who plan to seek industry funding to support their research on generative AI?*

Lastly, despite all the high expectations and massive investments in generative AI nowadays, a crucial question becomes: *"Are We in an AI Bubble?"*⁷ Some experts even predict that the current AI bubble may burst as early as in 2025⁸. Therefore, we will end this panel by discussing: *What is next? How can we better prepare our community members, including students and early career researchers, for the the potential post-AI era?*

The panel format will alternate between the moderator posing questions to the panelists, taking questions from the audience, and posing questions to the audience, to gather community opinions and ensure the panel is accessible to all participants.

¹<https://copilot.microsoft.com/>

²<https://gemini.google.com>

³<https://www.apple.com/apple-intelligence/>

⁴<https://www.meta.ai/>

⁵<https://www.europarl.europa.eu/topics/en/article/20230601STO93804/eu-ai-act-first-regulation-on-artificial-intelligence>

⁶<https://www.nsf.gov/focus-areas/artificial-intelligence>

⁷<https://money.usnews.com/investing/articles/are-we-in-an-ai-bubble>

⁸<https://www.forbes.com/sites/kolawolesamueladebayo/2025/01/20/experts-predict-the-bubble-may-burst-for-ai-in-2025/>

3 Organizers and Panelists

The moderator and panelists have expertise in the area of generative AI across various online contexts (e.g., games, XR, social media, conversational agents, and human-AI collaboration). The panelists also feature academic leaders in HCI/CSCW education and industry experts. Taken together, this panel brings unique knowledge and vision from academia and industry to this topic.

Guo Freeman (moderator) is an Associate Professor of Human-Centered Computing at Clemson University, USA. Her work has explored how interactive technologies such as digital games, live streaming, social VR, and AI shape interpersonal relationships and group behavior. Her most recent research focuses on AI-based moderation to mitigate emergent harassment risks in social VR and the impact of generative AI on creative technology workers.

Elizabeth Mynatt (panelist) is a professor and Dean of the Khoury College of Computer Sciences at Northeastern University, USA. She is an ACM Fellow and also serves as a member of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences and the ACM SIGCHI Academy. Her work has focused on human-centered AI for supporting older adults.

Cliff Lampe (panelist) is a Professor and Associate Dean for Academic Affairs at the University of Michigan School of Information, USA. He also serves as Chair of the CHI Steering Committee and is a member of the ACM SIGCHI Academy. His work has highlighted moderation in online spaces, the effects of harassment and disinformation in online spaces, and recently the motivations behind harassers in these spaces.

Heloisa Candello (panelist) is a senior research scientist in the Responsible Tech group at the IBM Research laboratory, Brazil. She currently serves as an ACM Distinguished Speaker, chairs the SIGCHI LATAM committee, and is a member of the CHI Steering Committee. Her research focuses on the intersection of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and Artificial Intelligence (AI), particularly in evaluating challenges and risks associated with conversational AI systems.

Kori Inkpen (panelist) is a Partner Research Manager at Microsoft Research, leading the Future Experiences (FX) team. The FX team is focused on envisioning next generation experiences that leverage emerging AI capabilities, including agents, generative user interfaces, and accessibility considerations.

Nitesh Goyal (panelist) leads Human-Centered Research at Google Deepmind about safety, leading to product launches with partners at public venues like Google I/O and award winning research papers. His work has focused on using AI responsibly at scale to deliver safer outcomes in society for at-risk humans in domains such as content moderation, online hate and harassment, synthetic content production, and analytic tools. He is serving a second term as an ACM Distinguished Speaker, and as a member of the CHI Steering Committee.

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